

Complete Hiring Guide for Cleaning Companies

The Cleaning CEO Blueprint — 100% Cleaner Academy

This guide walks you through hiring your first cleaner — and your tenth — without destroying your margins or your reputation.

When to Hire

Hire your first cleaner when:

- You are **turning away bookings** or working 50+ hours/week yourself
- You have **recurring revenue** covering at least 60% of a full week's payroll
- Your SOPs, checklists, and supplies are **documented** (you can't train without them)
- You can **afford 2–4 weeks** of payroll before the new hire is fully productive

Do NOT hire when:

- You're hiring out of panic after one busy week
- You don't know your true profit per job
- You have no quality control system (photos, inspections, callbacks)
- Cash flow can't cover a slow week + a no-show

Hiring Timeline Benchmark

Stage	Your Business
Solo owner-operator	0–\$8K/month
First 1–2 cleaners	\$8K–\$20K/month
Small team (3–5)	\$20K–\$50K/month
Multi-team operation	\$50K+/month

Independent Contractor vs. Employee

This is not legal advice. Consult a local employment attorney or CPA before classifying workers.

Independent Contractor (1099) — Common in cleaning startups

Typical traits (varies by state):

- Controls their own schedule within agreed windows
- Uses own vehicle (sometimes)
- Paid per job, not hourly
- Can work for other companies
- Responsible for their own taxes

Pros: Lower admin burden, per-job pay aligns with revenue

Cons: Misclassification risk if you micromanage like an employee; state laws differ sharply (especially CA, NY, NJ)

W-2 Employee

Typical traits:

- You set schedule, assign jobs, provide supplies
- You withhold taxes, may owe workers' comp and unemployment
- More control over quality and brand

Pros: Legal clarity when you direct daily work; easier to enforce uniforms and SOPs

Cons: Higher cost (payroll taxes, insurance, benefits); more paperwork

The 100% Cleaner Recommendation

Start with the classification your **state law and accountant** recommend — not what Facebook groups tell you. Many owners begin with per-job 1099 arrangements and transition to W-2 as they scale and exert more operational control.

Document everything: agreements, pay rates, scope of work, termination terms.

Full Hiring Process (Step by Step)

Phase 1: Prepare (Before You Post)

- ☐ Finalize pay rates (see Pay Structure below)
- ☐ Write job post with clear expectations
- ☐ Set up interview scoring sheet ([Interview Questions](#))
- ☐ Choose background check provider

- ☐ Prepare trial clean job (paid, real home or your own)
- ☐ Create onboarding packet (SOPs, checklists, contact list)

Phase 2: Recruit (Week 1)

Where to post:

- Indeed, Craigslist, Facebook local groups
- Nextdoor (service pros section)
- Referrals from existing cleaners (offer referral bonus)
- Instagram/Facebook story: "Hiring cleaners — flexible schedule"

Job post must include:

- Pay range (per job or hourly — be specific)
- Service area / cities covered
- Requirements: transportation, background check, smartphone
- Part-time vs. full-time availability
- Link or email to apply

Phase 3: Screen (Week 1–2)

1. **Application review** — filter for experience, location, availability
2. **15-minute phone screen** — use 5 questions from interview guide
3. **Schedule formal interview** — only top candidates

Phase 4: Interview (Week 2)

- 30–45 minute in-person or video interview
- Score every answer using rubric
- Explain pay structure, expectations, trial clean
- Minimum score: 70/100 to advance

Phase 5: Background Check

Run **after** strong interview, **before** or **during** trial clean.

Recommended checks:

- Criminal background (county + national)
- Sex offender registry (if allowed in your state)
- Motor vehicle record (if they drive to jobs)

- Identity verification

Popular providers: Checkr, GoodHire, Sterling, Accurate Background

Cost: ~\$30–\$80 per candidate. Build into hiring budget.

Note: Follow FCRA guidelines — get written consent, provide adverse action notices if you decline based on report.

Phase 6: Paid Trial Clean (Week 2–3)

- Pay full job rate (\$100 regular / \$200 deep or your rates)
- Assign experienced cleaner or you shadow
- Use trial scorecard from interview guide
- Client home (with permission) or your home staged as client

Pass criteria: Quality 4+/5, on time, followed SOP, professional communication

Phase 7: Offer & Onboarding (Week 3)

See Onboarding section below.

Pay Structure

The 100% Cleaner Model (Per Job)

Service	Customer Pays	Cleaner Pay	Company Profit	Supply Est.
Regular Clean	\$150	\$100	\$50	~\$8–\$12
Deep Clean	\$300	\$200	\$100	~\$15–\$25

Cleaner receives ~67% of job revenue. Your 33% covers:

- Scheduling and admin
- Marketing and lead cost
- Insurance and taxes
- Supplies (if you provide)
- Callbacks and quality issues
- Your salary as owner

Pay Schedule

Model	Frequency	Best For
Weekly	Every Friday	Cash flow stability for cleaners
Bi-weekly	Every other Friday	Easier admin
Per job (same day)	After completion	1099 contractors, small volume

Always pay on time. Late pay is the #1 reason cleaners leave or go independent.

Raises & Bonuses

- **After 90 days:** \$5–\$10/job increase if quality scores 4.5+ average
- **Referral bonus:** \$100–\$250 per hired cleaner who stays 90 days
- **Perfect month bonus:** No call-offs, 4.8+ client ratings
- **Lead cleaner premium:** +\$10–\$15/job for training new hires on-site

Background Checks — Deep Dive

What to look for

- **Theft, burglary, fraud** — high concern for in-home access
- **Violent offenses** — case-by-case with legal counsel
- **Recent DUI/reckless driving** — if driving company or client property

What requires nuance

- Old minor offenses (years ago, non-violent)
- Marijuana convictions in legal states
- Eviction history (not always on criminal report)

Have a written hiring policy so decisions are consistent, not arbitrary.

Bonding (Optional)

Janitorial bonding insures clients against theft. Costs ~\$100–\$500/year. Market as "bonded and insured" once active.

Onboarding Checklist

Day 1 — Paperwork & Orientation (2–3 hours)

- ☐ Signed contractor agreement or W-4 + I-9
- ☐ Direct deposit / payment info
- ☐ Emergency contact
- ☐ Background check consent (if not done)
- ☐ Review company values, dress code, communication rules
- ☐ Issue supplies kit or confirm they have required items
- ☐ Add to scheduling app, group chat, GPS tracking
- ☐ Walk through SOPs folder (Module 5 downloads)

Day 2–5 — Shadow Days

- ☐ Shadow you or lead cleaner on 2–3 jobs
- ☐ Perform tasks with supervision
- ☐ Practice photo documentation (arrival, before/after, issues)
- ☐ Review quality control checklist

Week 2 — Solo with Backup

- ☐ Assign solo jobs (regular cleans only, no deep/move-out yet)
- ☐ You or lead cleaner available by phone
- ☐ End-of-day debrief first week

Day 30 — Review

- ☐ Quality audit on 2 random jobs
- ☐ Client feedback review
- ☐ Confirm fit or part ways (document performance)

Supplies Kit (If You Provide)

Item	Qty
Microfiber cloths (color-coded)	12
Bathroom cleaner	1
All-purpose cleaner	1
Glass cleaner	1

Scrub brush set	1
Extendable duster	1
Caddy or tote	1
Gloves	1 box
Company shirt (optional)	2

Training Priorities (First 30 Days)

1. **SOP compliance** — same result every home
 2. **Photo documentation** — protects you and them
 3. **Communication** — running late, issues, supply needs
 4. **Time management** — regular clean in 2–3 hours for standard 3/2
 5. **Client boundaries** — no personal conversations about pricing, no side deals
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Retention — Keep Good Cleaners

- Pay on time, every time
 - Don't overload schedule (burnout kills quality)
 - Respond to texts same day
 - Celebrate wins publicly in team chat
 - Clear path to lead cleaner role
 - Fair callback policy (not always cleaner's fault)
 - Listen when they say a client is unreasonable
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Termination — When & How

Terminate when:

- Repeated no-shows without notice
- Theft or dishonesty (document everything)
- Client safety concerns
- Refusal to follow SOPs after written warning

- Background issue discovered that violates policy

Process:

1. Verbal warning (document date and issue)
2. Written warning with specific improvement plan (7–14 days)
3. Final written warning
4. Termination letter — pay all owed wages immediately per state law
5. Recover keys, supplies, company shirt
6. Remove from apps, group chats, client access

Hiring Budget Template

Item	Cost
Job board posts (Indeed, etc.)	\$50–\$200
Background checks (per hire)	\$30–\$80
Trial clean pay	\$100–\$200
Supplies kit	\$75–\$150
Uniform/shirt	\$20–\$40
Referral bonus (optional)	\$100–\$250
Total per hire	\$375–\$920

Plan to interview 5–10 candidates per open position.

Quick Reference: Hiring Funnel

Applications (20–50)



Phone screens (8–12)



Interviews (4–6)



Background checks (2–3)



Trial cleans (2)



Hire (1)

*Consult local employment law before classifying workers. Customize all rates for your market.
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